

Reflection

“Do you remember when she and I were dating?” my brother recalled while blowing smoke out of his mouth. I could barely comprehend the question as I was focused on my own cigarette, a much-needed break after the wild couple hours of drinking done drinking at my party. I was getting married and this was my bachelor party, so why would my own brother drop this on me now?

“I don’t, I just remember the two of you being friends.” It was a pretty obvious lie, I did know they were a thing for a time. He shifted his body towards me, he clearly knew I was being oblivious on purpose. My brother was always good at reading people, unlike me. It’s something I try to keep out of my mind, my brother always got what he wanted as he was older I was just the strange younger sibling.

“You really didn’t know we were a thing? I thought you two would’ve talked about it by now.” He took another long puff of his cigarette, almost seemed confident blowing out the smoke like he was pleased by something he said.

“I don’t want her to have to explain her past choices, we are who we are now and that’s enough for me.” She really was a different person now, we both are. I’m not the kid who sat alone every day at lunch because I was into coding. I’m in a happy relationship with the love of my life whom I’m getting married to in a few days.

“Wow, my little brother is all grown up.” He said wiping a fake tear from his eyes, in the process accidentally put some ashes into his eye.

“Hey, do you remember Michaela’s party when we were in high school?” He remarked while trying to rub the ashes out of his eyes. I couldn’t for a moment, it was so long ago and I’ve tried to put the memories of that godforsaken place out of my mind.

“You mean the one you got super drunk at and almost drowned?” He was so reckless that night, I can’t believe that we are related sometimes. The memory I had just unearthed seemed to please him in a way that confused me.

“Oh yeah, that did happen.” He chuckled a bit while taking another puff. “But I was actually referring to when we were doing truth or dare and she ended up making out with that guy from the football team. That was amazing, she’s always been a big party girl, imagine what she and her girlfriends are doing right now *woof*.” What a weird story? He looked extremely titillated with his large smile, but his eyes seemed sad. Why is he acting like this?

“I think I was sick and in the bathroom at the point.” Which was the truth, I was a pretty big lightweight back then and the several slices of pizza surely didn’t help.

“Right. Well, she’s still the same when it comes to partying, is what I meant. Always doing wild things.” It seemed like he was trying to hide something from his tone, it seemed sharper than

usual. Not only that, he seemed more fidgety than usually moving his cigarette from hand to hand while talking.

“Well she just likes to unwind after work, she does have a lot on her shoulders these days.” Again the truth. She’s a Real Estate agent and it was her job to make any house marketable even if it really wasn’t.

“I’ve never known anyone else who can down a keg as she can, you’re a lucky one.” He always knew how to make a compliment sound strange.

“Thanks, I guess. Um, should we- ““OH HEY, remember when she was arrested for public indecency and you had to go get her. Man, you look like a disappointed parent” He gave a roaring chuckle that sounded a bit like a cackle or am I being paranoid?

I was caught off guard by his sudden interruption, but I did remember that. It wasn’t the first time her late-night drinking led to something bad happening.

“She doesn’t do it that much anymore, we agreed she would be more responsible.” The music in the bar seemed louder to me now and more welcoming than the conversation right now.

“Really, then why was she completely out of it when she came to my place last week?” My cigarette fell out of my hands and my eyes were immediately drawn to his face. He was almost giddy, like a kid who is telling on their sibling to get in good with their parents.

“Yeah, she came by and we just hung out no need to worry about it.” Was that a lie? He was always good at lying. He seemed so sure about every word, it was really hard to peg my brother. Which was probably why he had trouble maintaining relationships as he was hard to get close to.

“Anyway let’s head back, we got to make the most out of your party you won’t be a bachelor for long.” He nudged me a bit before putting out his cigarette and heading back inside. Leaving me there. When was the last time she and I went on a date?

The Forest

Beep, Beep, Beep, this droning noise woke the young girl from her unconscious state. The girl was named Lilith, a normal girl who went to school and lived with her parents like most of people can relate to. However, she has just found herself in a dark forest alone.

“Hello?” she squeaked out, the grogginess of her slumber and the fear of being in an unknown place made her voice crack.

“Is anyone there?” this time her call was a bit clearer. It was louder to so someone was sure to hear it, at least she thought it would but several minutes of nothing proved her wrong.

Helplessness quickly flooded her mind taking the place of the hope someone might be able to help. The giant, black trees surrounded her like bars on a jail cell. Twisting in all direction, reaching towards the sky with its skinny branches. She couldn't stay here much longer, so she decided to follow the only path she could see, it was an average dirt path that extended in front of her. Of course, she was afraid to leave the assumed safety of the clearing she had woken up in, but help was not coming. While walking on the path the trapped feeling grew larger and larger as it narrowed. Lilith was usually a pretty confident girl, but a situation such as this was bound to bring anyone anxiety. Her chest was tight, the pressure almost resembled that of weight. It was suffocating, the faintness she was experiencing also hindered her movement making her walk on the path slow. She wanted nothing more than to escape this awful place, yet her body was making that an ever-increasing challenge.

She decided to take a moment to re-center herself, she knew that continuing the way she was would only cause more inconveniences. Deep breathing, a technique taught in school at those talks that always came around towards the end of a semester. She didn't really pay much attention to those, but the simple stuff like the deep breathing was easy to retain. In and out, she breathed in an almost hypnotizing motion that took form for only a short time. Yet it was extremely effective, in a matter of minutes she had pretty much calmed herself down. The shaking had subsided and the weight holding down her chest lightened up. While feeling better her mind reeled back to before she was in this place. All she could recall was running from something and then a bright light. Also, the beeping noise that had woken her up was a lot quieter but still audible. She listened closely to see if it was something she could follow to find help when she heard a screeching moan. It was close and getting closer by the moment.

Lilith scanned the surroundings around her, her head moving in a wild in panic pattern due to panic the deep breathing she had used to calm herself now irrelevant. She finally spotted the thing making the noise. It was a large man if you could even call it a man, it looked humanoid but its arms dragged far too low to the ground. When it was closer and easier to see, the thing had on a torn sweater, polo shirt, and jeans. However, the thing that terrified Lilith the most was its face. Or should its lack of face. Clearly, this thing wasn't human, the long arms and lack of face and no ears made it pretty clear. Nearly paralyzed by the horror that was shambling towards her, she managed to free herself and run wildly off the path. The foliage cut her legs quite a bit, but she couldn't feel the pain. The fear of whatever that thing was or what it could do to her was overwhelming. She had never felt intense fear like that, even her greatest fear of spiders didn't fill her with the kind of dread she was dealing with. She glanced only once, and that was a massive mistake.

Not only was that thing following her, but it was faster than before. In fact, it was gaining on her rather fast. This only amplified her flight mechanism, but because she looked away from where she was running for a moment, she tripped. The ground came up hard and her ankle was now entangled in a rouge branch making her doom ever eminent. She tried her best to set herself free; she pulled, struggled, and clawed to try to get the branch loose but to no avail. The creature was coming fast, it almost looked like it was flying. However, she couldn't dwell on that for long, it was coming.

"Please! Just leave me alone!" she cried the tears stinging her face were the only things, besides fear, she felt at that moment. Yet, the creature did not seem to care.

Then the creature stopped inches away from her face. Her pupils gyrated wildly as she tried to break free, but was completely paralyzed by its 'stare'. The creature then began to raise its large hands to her neck, slowly as if it was trying to play with her. Like a hunter playing with its prey for its temporary amusement before enjoying the kill.

"No!" she yelled in desperation. She didn't care if the thing couldn't hear her, she just wanted it to stop, wanted something to save her from this grizzly fate. She just wanted to go home, have a nice warm dinner, and sleep in her room.

Then nothing. Suddenly everything was all white. Slowly the bright whites faded, revealing a pair of wings flourished right in front of her eyes. They were quite lovely, a dark grey with black tips. They looked rather soft and for some reason felt welcoming to her.

“Are you alright?” a calm voice ushered away the silence replacing it with a question Lilith hoped to hear ever since she woke up in this place.

She looked up at the person who saved her life and realized something, this ‘person’ wasn’t human either. They had completely black eyes, along with black marks on their arms, hands, and face. However, that all paled in comparison to the halo hovering over their head and the as for mentioned wings. In their hands, two sickles and in the ground the terrifying corpse of the thing that had attacked her.

“I’m- o-ok...” she yelped rather quietly. Clearly this was not the case, yet the main source of her misery was gone, presumably.

The winged person knelt down, using their weapons to carve away the roots that entangled her ankles. After the roots were promptly dealt with, they helped her to stand up. When she did Lilith could get a better look at her strange savior. They had a swoopy set of grey hair that aided in their soft appearance. The halo also had points, as if it was the child of a wreath and a halo. Then the creature stood up. Lilith screamed in horror but was promptly silenced by the strange person. After a grueling few moments of silence, the creature eventually went on its way back into the never-ending wood. As soon as the person confirmed it was gone, they removed their hand off of Lilith’s mouth. She let out a relieved sigh.

“Th-thank y-you.” she mustered out, she was still rather exhausted from her encounter with the beast. “Um- Do you know where we are?” That question was still on her mind, and she thought it wouldn’t hurt to ask. This person clearly knew more about that creature than she did, so they must know about this odd forest.

“We are in Limbo.” they replied bluntly, not even bothering to look at her.

“E-excuse me?” This person must be insane, sure the creature and their obvious angel features were odd, but she couldn’t possibly be in Limbo. Could she?

“I assume you woke up here? Then that means something on earth caused your soul to leave your body and end up here.” They lacked any emotion in their voice. They almost sounded like a text-to-speech bot.

“Then what happened to me?” she screamed, tears began to well up in her eyes once more.

“What do you remember?” they retorted.

“I remember running, and then a bright light. Then the sound of beeping.” This was true. That was the only thing she could recall from before arriving in Limbo apparently.

“Sounds like a textbook car accident to me.” they replied bluntly while putting their weapons on their back.

“What!” Lilith was completely appalled. A car accident! How did they possibly get a car accident from her explanation? Was this some sort of elaborate joke, her friend was very fond of this stuff, maybe she was playing a prank on Lilith? Or was this person telling the truth. Her route home from school did involve crossing several streets that needed to be crossed. Did she get into an accident?

“Listen.” he finally turned to face her. “People end up in Limbo either because they have some sort of tie binding them to the realms of living or dead, or because they can accept their own death.” They paused for a moment to gauge her reaction, then continued. “Either you died in that car crash, or what is most likely the case, you ended up in a coma and are now in a hospital attached to some sort of machine that is making that odd beep.”

She supposed it could be possible, she did hear from her friend that comas are like out of body experiences. Maybe they were right after all, everything about this place was far from normal. So maybe this angel was right, she really was in a coma and was hit by a car.

“How do I wake up?” she was still a bit skeptical, but she would literally try anything to go home. She had, frankly, enough of this place and just wanted to see her mother at least.

“I could wake you, but once you die permanently your soul would belong to Me.” they seemed incredibly serious. She would really have to offer up her soul? She thought that was reserved to deals with demons not angels, yet I suppose that didn’t matter in a place like Limbo.

“Do we have a deal?” they held out their hand, most likely for her to seal whatever she was about to seal. She didn’t really want to make a deal as serious as this, however this place was awful and she did want to risk running into any more creatures.

“Of course, as long as I get to leave.” they nodded as she shook their hand. Another flash of bright white light enveloping her once more.

Beep, Beep, Beep, this droning noise woke the young girl from her unconscious state. She was in a hospital hooked up to various medical equipment, unaware of the cause of her situation or the encounter she had with the angel of death. Not even noticing the same angel was staring at her from the window hovering almost mechanically in the air. They knew she wouldn’t recall the experiences she had gone through during her coma. As those who leave Limbo, forget their time in Limbo.